



Partly sunny, windy 36/25 • Tomorrow: Mostly cloudy 37/27 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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RICKY CARIOTI/THE WASHINGTON POST

House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) delivers remarks at the Capitol after being reelected to the leadership role Friday. He was able to clinch the necessary 218 votes on the first ballot despite resistance from the ultraconservative flank of his party.

Johnson narrowly wins speakership

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR, JACQUELINE ALEMANY, LEIGH ANN CALDWELL AND MARIANNE LEVINE

Speaker Mike Johnson will continue to lead House Republicans in the 119th Congress, a victory for the Louisiana Republican and for President-elect Donald Trump's agenda.

The win came after a tense standoff with Republican lawmakers and a phone call from Trump to two members of the ultraconservative House Freedom Caucus, highlighting the soon-to-be president's sway over the fractious House Republican majority.

Trump threw his weight behind Johnson earlier this week,

Trump helps flip two GOP holdouts in early victory for his agenda

but three Republicans voted against his wishes on Friday: Reps. Thomas Massie (Kentucky), Ralph Norman (South Carolina) and Keith Self (Texas). When it became clear that Johnson did not have the votes, House Republicans began to call Trump and his key allies to urge them to convince the holdouts.

Massie had been staunchly against Johnson's leadership and signaled to his colleagues that he would not flip. Rep. Nancy Mace

(R-South Carolina) called Trump, who was golfing, and passed her phone to Norman, Norman said. Trump also spoke with Self and helped persuade both to change their votes for Johnson, according to several lawmakers.

Johnson huddled privately with Self and Norman, and they took another call from Trump, according to two people familiar with the matter who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss private conversations. Then Johnson and his allies gathered with the holdouts and other Freedom Caucus members, emerging victorious as Norman and Self changed their votes.

In the end, it took Johnson just one ballot to clinch the necessary

218 votes, while all 215 Democrats supported Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D-New York).

The dramatic turnaround was a significant boost for Johnson, who will be spared — for now — from the kind of protracted battle that saw then-Rep. Kevin McCarthy (R-California) spend days hashing out deals only to lose 14 rounds of voting before he won the gavel.

Though having the speaker decision sorted will help Republicans focus on policy, Friday's vote hinted at just how hard it will be for Johnson to keep fellow Republicans in line through the months ahead.

In addition to the three initial votes against Johnson, six other

SEE JOHNSON ON A4

Judge upholds Trump's N.Y. felony verdict

SENTENCING IS JAN. 10 IN HUSH MONEY CASE

President-elect is not expected to face jail time

BY SHAYNA JACOBS AND DAVID NAKAMURA

NEW YORK — President-elect Donald Trump will be sentenced on 34 counts of falsifying business records ahead of his swearing-in Jan. 20 but is not expected to face jail time, a judge ruled Friday.

The decision to uphold Trump's conviction and schedule the sentencing for Jan. 10 almost certainly means Trump will be the first felon to serve as a U.S. president.

New York Supreme Court Justice Juan Merchan wrote in his ruling that he does not intend to sentence Trump to jail. He said he plans to order an "unconditional discharge," a designation in New York criminal courts for a non-jail and non-probation sentence that carries no other obli-

gations.

The sentencing hearing is scheduled a day after Trump is set to attend memorial services in Washington for former president Jimmy Carter, who died Dec. 29 at age 100. Merchan said Trump has the option of attending the hearing at the courthouse in downtown Manhattan or participating via an online video link.

Trump was convicted in May of falsifying business records to conceal a hush money payment to an adult-film star ahead of the 2016 election. He faced up to four years in prison, but many experts said incarceration was unlikely because of his age and his lack of prior convictions.

Trump is expected to appeal and may try other legal avenues in the next week to try to stop the

SEE TRUMP ON A4

Biden blocks U.S. Steel sale, cuing court battle

BY DAVID J. LYNCH AND JEFF STEIN

President Joe Biden's decision Friday to block the sale of U.S. Steel to a Japanese rival has ignited an imminent legal challenge, alarmed foreign investors and cast a shadow over the careers of several thousand American steelworkers the White House says it wants to help.

Biden's rejection of the deal came in a presidential order posted on the White House website, declaring Nippon Steel's \$14.9 billion bid for the U.S. steelmaker "prohibited." The president acted to safeguard the domestic steel

industry, which he believed was in danger of being swamped by excess foreign production by nations such as China, according to Robyn Patterson, a White House spokeswoman.

"This acquisition would place one of America's largest steel producers under foreign control and create risk for our national security and our critical supply chains," Biden said.

When announced in December 2023, the trans-Pacific marriage was billed as a way to create a plus-sized steelmaker that could compete on the global stage with the largest Chinese companies.

SEE U.S. STEEL ON A12

U.S. surgeon general urges cancer labels for alcohol

BY FENIT NIRAPPII AND VIVIAN HO

Health warning labels on alcohol should be updated to include a cancer risk warning, the U.S. surgeon general said Friday, adding that recommended limits for alcohol consumption should also be reassessed, given the increased risk of certain cancers.

Alcohol consumption is the third-leading preventable cause of cancer in the United States behind tobacco and obesity, Vivek H. Murthy said in an advisory. It contributes to 100,000 cancer cases and 20,000 related deaths each year, he added.

The link between alcohol and cancer has been established for decades. The National Toxicology Program in 2000 listed alcoholic beverages as a carcinogen, while an agency of the World Health Organization began doing so in 1987. But most Americans do not know about the connection, Murthy said.

"This evidence has been built-

SEE ALCOHOL ON A12

REPRESSION'S LONG ARM

In India's shadow war, a campaign of covert killings

Recent assassinations inside Pakistan's borders resemble operations targeting enemies in the West

BY GERRY SHIH

LAHORE, PAKISTAN — Shortly after 12:30 p.m. on a sweltering day in April, two masked gunmen walked into a working-class home in Lahore, identified a 48-year-old man known as Tamba and fired three shots at close range into his chest and leg, according to a Pakistani police report. The assailants then sped off on a Honda motorbike, leaving Tamba in a pool of blood on the second floor.

Tamba, whose real name was Amir Sarfraz, had old enemies. The gangster had been accused of beating an Indian intelligence agent to death inside a Lahore prison in 2011 while both men were serving time on death row, but he was released, cleared of charges. Outraged Indian authorities suspected that Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence agency, or ISI, had hired Tamba to carry out the jailhouse murder, according to a former Indian official, and now, 13 years later, they seemed to get their revenge.

Soon after, Pakistani Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi told

SEE INDIA ON A8



AMINA YASEEN/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A street vendor in Lahore. After the April shooting of a man known as Tamba, Pakistani Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi said several similar killings showed signs of "India's direct involvement."

Vienna plot, New Orleans attack carry ISIS's imprint

BY SOUAD MEKHENNET AND JOBY WARRICK

By the time he came up with the idea of bombing a Taylor Swift concert, Beran Aliji's young life had completely broken down. In July, amid a self-described mental crisis, the 19-year-old Austrian abruptly quit his job as a factory apprentice and isolated himself in his apartment, obsessing, as he later told police, about his own death.

With no money or prospects, and in lieu of close friendships, he began to immerse himself in a virtual world of violent videos and secret chatrooms devoted to the Islamic State. According to phone records seized by police, he began looking to the extremist group first for inspiration and then for practical advice about planning an attack.

"My operation is to take place at a big concert," he wrote in a text message to a stranger he believed to be a member of the Islamic State, according to Aus-

SEE ISIS ON A5

IN THE NEWS

Las Vegas explosion The soldier found dead in the Cybertruck, a member of a Special Forces unit, spoke of having had a brain injury, a former girlfriend told The Post. A3

A lifetime of service Upon his retirement, Sen. Ben Cardin (D) reflected on a six-decade legacy and his impact on Maryland. B1

THE NATION The FDA is weighing a ban on a red food dye that's been linked to cancer in animals. A2
A looming storm could spread snow and ice from Nebraska to the Washington region. A3

THE WORLD Northern Israel calmed after the Hezbollah ceasefire, but families are staying away. A6
South Korean officials were blocked from detaining the impeached leader by his guards. A7

THE ECONOMY JetBlue was fined \$2 million by the Transportation Department for operating "chronically delayed flights" in 2022 and 2023. A10
Elon Musk's decision to help Las Vegas investors shows a selective willingness to use the data Tesla collects. A11

THE REGION The Key Bridge rebuilding project in Baltimore is slated to begin next week. B1
The Loudoun County courthouse, which is named after civil rights attorney Charles Hamilton Houston, was declared a national historical landmark. B1

STYLE Netflix's adaptation of "One Hundred Years of Solitude" is a witty, improbable triumph, television critic Lili Loofbourow writes. C1

SPORTS Tiger Woods is among those backing — and playing in — a high-tech indoor golf league. D1

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